

Sam Short Splashed to Four Golds -- and a World Record!

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Picture this: you dive into the pool and swim so fast that no one in the world has ever gone quicker without a fancy super-suit! That's what Sam Short did. At the Australian Swimming Trials, he won four races: the 200, 400, 800, and 1500 meters **freestyle**. That's like being the fastest sprinter AND the best marathon runner at the same time! In the 800, he touched the wall in 7 minutes and 36.73 seconds a new world record for **textile suits** (the regular kind, not the super-fast rubber ones banned years ago). The last Australian man to sweep all four events was Grant Hackett way back in 2005. Sam's journey wasn't always smooth. In 2024, he got sick and missed the finals at the **Olympics**. He called it a "**failure**." But he bounced back, fixed his shoulder, and now he's on fire. He even said the 1500 isn't his main focus anymore, but he still won it! "Good to see I've still got it," he joked on Instagram. With the **Commonwealth Games** coming up, everyone will be watching to see if Sam can break more records. Maybe he'll even make a splash bigger than a **cannonball**!

Word Treasure

freestyle -- A swimming race where you can use any stroke, but most swimmers use the front crawl.

textile suits -- Regular fabric swimsuits; the super-fast rubber suits were banned years ago.

Olympics -- The world's biggest sports competition, held every four years with athletes from many countries.

Commonwealth Games -- A sports event for countries that were once part of the British Empire, like a mini-Olympics.

failure -- When you try to achieve something and don't succeed, even though you worked hard.

cannonball -- A fun jump into water where you curl up and make a big splash.

Background you need

Grant Hackett (a legendary Australian distance swimmer) was the last to win all four freestyle events in 2005. He dominated swimming in the early 2000s and inspired a generation of Australian swimmers, including Sam Short.

High-tech rubber swimsuits were banned in 2010 because they gave swimmers an unfair advantage by making them more buoyant and slippery. All records set after the ban are called 'textile bests' because they are set in fabric swimsuits.

The Commonwealth Games is a multi-sport event held every four years, featuring athletes from countries like Australia, Canada, India, and others that were once part of the British Empire. It's one of the biggest stages for swimmers from these nations.

Break it down

WHO: Sam Short, an Australian swimmer who bounced back from injury and illness.

WHAT: He won four gold medals (200, 400, 800, and 1500m freestyle) and set a world record in the 800m in a textile suit.

WHERE: At the Australian Swimming Trials.

WHY: After failing to make the Olympic finals in 2024, he trained hard to prove he's still a champion, and the upcoming Commonwealth Games give him another chance to shine.

Why it matters

Sam's comeback shows that failing once doesn't mean you're done -- you can always learn, get stronger, and surprise yourself and everyone else.

Test what you remember

1. How many races did Sam Short win at the Australian Swimming Trials?
 - (A) two
 - (B) three
 - (C) four
 - (D) five
2. In which event did Sam set a world record?
 - (A) 200 meters freestyle
 - (B) 400 meters freestyle
 - (C) 800 meters freestyle
 - (D) 1500 meters freestyle
3. What kind of swimsuit was Sam wearing for his world record?
 - (A) A high-tech rubber super-suit
 - (B) A regular textile suit
 - (C) A wetsuit
 - (D) No suit at all
4. Who was the last Australian man to sweep all four freestyle events before Sam?
 - (A) Ian Thorpe
 - (B) Grant Hackett
 - (C) Sam Short's coach
 - (D) No one, it had never been done
5. What happened to Sam at the 2024 Olympics?
 - (A) He won a gold medal
 - (B) He got sick and missed the finals
 - (C) He broke a world record
 - (D) He switched to running
6. What did Sam say about winning the 1500 meters race?
 - (A) It was his main focus
 - (B) He was disappointed
 - (C) He joked, 'Good to see I've still got it'
 - (D) He decided to quit swimming

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: C 3: B 4: B 5: B 6: C

Questions to think about

1. **Sam Short and his supporters:** They see his four golds and world record as proof that resilience pays off. Sam himself calls his 2024 miss a 'failure' but uses it as fuel to swim faster, showing a positive attitude toward setbacks.
2. **His competitors:** Other swimmers might feel increased pressure because Sam has returned so strongly. His sweep of all four events sends a message that he's the one to beat, which could push them to train even harder.
3. **Swimming fans and historians:** They appreciate that Sam's record came in a regular textile suit, linking him to a fairer era of swimming. They compare him to legends like Grant Hackett and wonder if he can break more records without the help of old 'super-suits.'

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):